DSEH001 · DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION IN HR SYSTEMS

02

UNIT 2 READER

Building and Rolling Out Digital HR

HRIS, electronic HRM, adoption and change

Weeks 4 to 6 | Exam preparation | 14 readings explained

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About this reader

> **How to use it.** This reader is a companion to the set readings, not a replacement for them. For each reading it explains the argument in plain language, lists the ideas you must hold, shows how to apply them, flags common confusions, and gives questions to think with as you prepare for the end-term examination. Read the original first, then use this reader to check your understanding. Folder names refer to the course Readings folder.

Unit 2 moves from diagnosis to design and delivery. Its first half is about architecture: what an HR information system is, how its parts should fit together, and how privacy must be built in rather than bolted on. Its second half is about people: why employees adopt or ignore a new system, and how a change program can move them from knowing a system exists to using it and recommending it to others.

The readings come from two research traditions that you should learn to combine. Information systems research (Venkatesh and colleagues, Bondarouk and colleagues) explains adoption through perceptions, conditions and context. Change management (Lewin, Kotter, Prosci ADKAR, Everett Rogers) explains how to lead people through a transition. A strong examination answer uses the first tradition to find where a group is stuck, and the second to choose the fix that matches that stuck point.

READING MAP

Week	Set readings	Folder	Exam-edition lectures
4	Bondarouk, Parry and Furtmueller (2017); Kavanagh and Johnson (2018) Ch 1 and 3; an Indian HRIS or ATS case. Frameworks: three layer architecture; Privacy by Design	Unit-2 Core, Unit-2 Supp.	L1, L2
5	Scully-Russ and Torraco (2020) pp. 83 to 84; Infosys Lex case; NASSCOM FutureSkills. India Stack (onboarding). Frameworks: ADKAR; Lewin and Kotter; Everett Rogers; nudges	Unit-1 Core, Unit-1 Supp.	L1, L2
6	Bondarouk et al. (2017) adoption sections; Venkatesh et al. (2003); Manuti and de Palma (2018) Ch 4 and 5	Unit-2 Core	L1 to L3

The readings, one by one

Week 4 Core

Bondarouk, T., Parry, E., & Furtmueller, E. (2017). Electronic HRM: Four decades of research on adoption and consequences. *The International Journal of Human Resource Management*, 28(1), 98 to 131.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

This is a systematic review of forty years of research on electronic HRM. The authors organize what is known about adoption into three groups of factors: technology (how useful and usable the system is), organization (support, resources, culture, the role of the HR function) and people (attitudes, skills and experience of users). They then review the consequences of electronic HRM and find that most studies report operational gains such as speed and lower cost, while evidence on relational and strategic outcomes is weaker and mixed. Their critique of the field is that much research describes rather than explains, and that adoption and consequences are rarely studied together.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Adoption depends on technology, organization and people factors together.
- Operational outcomes are well documented; relational and strategic outcomes much less so.
- Adoption and consequences should be studied as one chain, not separately.
- Context, including national and organizational culture, shapes both.

APPLY IT

Use the three factor groups to structure any diagnosis of low adoption. A single-factor explanation (for example, 'they need training') is usually incomplete.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Do not cite Bondarouk, Ruël and Parry, *Electronic HRM in the Smart Era*, in place of this article. It is a different work and is background only.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- For one employee segment with low adoption, list one technology, one organization and one people factor that could explain it.

Week 4 Core

Kavanagh, M. J., & Johnson, R. D. (2018). Chapters 1 and 3.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Chapter 1 explains what an HRIS is and does, and how it differs from electronic HRM: the HRIS is the information system, while electronic HRM is the way HR practices are delivered to employees and managers through it. Chapter 3 turns to architecture: how HR systems are put together, the move to cloud and mobile delivery, and the choice between one integrated suite and a set of best of breed applications. The practical message is that architecture decisions fix the cost, flexibility and integration burden of everything built later.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- An HRIS is the information system; electronic HRM is how HR is delivered through it.
- Cloud and mobile delivery change who can reach the system, not only where it runs.
- Suite or best of breed: integration ease against fit for each process.
- Architecture choices fix the integration burden for years.

APPLY IT

Architecture choices decide who can reach the system. Ask how many systems are mobile-enabled, and who a desktop-only suite would leave out.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Suite versus best of breed is an architecture choice. Build versus buy versus configure is a sourcing choice. Week 4 L1 covers both; keep them apart.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Make the case for a suite and the case for best of breed for a large Indian retailer. Which evidence decides it?

Week 4 Case

An Indian HRIS or ATS implementation case (shared in class)

HOW TO READ IT

Read the case with the two Week 4 questions in mind: what architecture and sourcing choice the firm made, and who its ATS or HRIS could not reach or screened out. Then evaluate the choice using the suite versus best-of-breed and build, buy or configure frameworks.

Week 4 **Framework**

Course framing: the three layer architecture (System of Record, Engagement, Insight).

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

The course uses a three layer architecture framing. The System of Record is the single authoritative source of employee data (who works here, in what role, on what pay). The Engagement layer is how people interact with HR: self service apps, chatbots, learning platforms. The Insight layer turns data into analysis and decisions. The design rule is one record only: every engagement and insight tool should read from and write to the same system of record, so that the organization never holds two conflicting versions of an employee.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- System of Record: one authoritative employee record.
- Engagement: the channels employees and managers actually touch.
- Insight: analytics and reporting built on the record.
- Two systems of record create duplicate, conflicting data and weaken every layer above.

APPLY IT

When an organization holds two systems claiming to be the record, decide which becomes the System of Record and what happens to the other.

EASY TO CONFUSE

This framing is the course's own; credit it to the course, not to Kavanagh. It is also not a maturity ladder: the layers coexist, they are not stages.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- What criteria (integration, deployment, adoption, data quality) should decide which system becomes the System of Record?

Week 4 Framework

Cavoukian, A. (2011). *Privacy by Design: The 7 foundational principles*. Information and Privacy Commissioner of Ontario. ISO/IEC 27701:2025.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Privacy by Design holds that privacy should be built into systems from the start and set as the default, rather than added after a problem appears. Its principles include being proactive rather than reactive, making privacy the default setting, embedding it into the design, protecting data through its whole life cycle, and keeping processing visible and user centered. ISO/IEC 27701 sets out a privacy information management system that gives organizations an auditable structure for these practices. Its 2019 edition was an extension of ISO/IEC 27001; the revised edition published in October 2025 is a standalone standard, so certification no longer requires ISO/IEC 27001 first. In the Indian setting, these ideas are the practical route to meeting DPDP duties such as purpose limitation and data minimization.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Proactive, not reactive; privacy as the default setting.
- Consent, purpose limitation and data minimization designed into each flow.
- Protection across the full life of the data, including deletion.
- ISO/IEC 27701 (2025 edition, now standalone) provides an auditable management system for privacy.

APPLY IT

For each layer of an HR architecture, state what data it collects, for what purpose, where it is stored and when it is deleted. Data residency is a design input, not an afterthought.

EASY TO CONFUSE

A compliance audit checks what already exists. Privacy by Design shapes what you are about to build.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Name one common HR data flow that would fail data minimization.

Week 5 Framework

India Stack: Aadhaar eKYC, UPI and DigiLocker as public digital infrastructure.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

India Stack is a set of public digital rails: identity verification through Aadhaar eKYC, payments through UPI, and verified document storage through DigiLocker. For HR, these rails can remove paper from onboarding and payments for a frontline workforce that may lack laptops or formal banking habits. Their attraction is reach and low cost; their risk is that identity and financial data are highly sensitive, so every use must meet the DPDP Act's tests of purpose, consent and security.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Public rails can make onboarding and payment possible on a basic phone.
- Reach and cost favor them for large frontline populations.
- Sensitive identity and payment data raise the bar for consent and security.

> **APPLY IT**
>
> Compare an India Stack approach with a mobile-first HRMS for frontline staff in smaller towns. Which reaches feature phone users at all?

> **QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH**
>
> - What would an onboarding flow using DigiLocker remove, and what new risk would it add?

Week 5 Core

Scully-Russ, E., & Torraco, R. J. (2020). Pages 83 to 84.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

The Week 5 pages describe new models of education and workplace learning: short micro courses, learning on demand at the moment of need, and a role for HR development as the architect of learning systems rather than the provider of single courses. As tasks change, workers need continuous learning rather than one time training. The authors connect this to a wider shift in the employment relationship: responsibility for development is increasingly shared between employer and worker, which can leave less protected workers behind if support is not designed for them.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Micro courses and on demand learning replace one time training.
- HR development becomes the architect of learning systems.
- Responsibility for development is shifting toward workers.
- Less protected workers risk being left behind without designed support.

APPLY IT

Ask whether an organization's learning offer reaches the people whose roles are changing fastest, by delivery mode and by employee segment.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Is self-paced mobile learning a fair default for a frontline workforce? What evidence would settle the question?

Week 5 **Case**

Case: Infosys Lex, digital reskilling at scale. NASSCOM FutureSkills (latest), selected sections.

HOW TO READ IT

These two Week 5 readings show learning systems built for scale in India: an employer's own learning platform, and an industry skilling initiative for emerging technologies. As you read, ask which features would and would not carry over to a frontline, smartphone-only, multilingual workforce in smaller towns.

Week 5 **Framework**

Hiatt, J. M. (2006). ADKAR: A *model for change in business, government and our community*. Prosci.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

ADKAR describes individual change as five elements in a fixed order: Awareness of the need for change, Desire to take part, Knowledge of how to change, Ability to put that knowledge into practice, and Reinforcement to sustain it. Its practical value is diagnostic. Find the first element where a person or group is stuck, and fix that element; effort spent further along the sequence is wasted. Knowledge (knowing how) and Ability (being able to do it in real conditions) are often confused, and the gap between them is where many training programs fail.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Five elements in order: Awareness, Desire, Knowledge, Ability, Reinforcement.
- Diagnose the first stuck element, then match the fix to it.
- Knowledge is knowing how; Ability is doing it in real conditions with real constraints.
- Reinforcement keeps people from slipping back after the launch energy fades.

APPLY IT

Map adoption stages to ADKAR with care. A trained employee with low system use may be stuck at Ability or Desire, not Knowledge.

EASY TO CONFUSE

An ADKAR Ability barrier is not the same as a digital inclusion Access barrier. If a person has no suitable device, no amount of practice builds Ability.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- For a smartphone-only, low-literacy employee who completed training but rarely logs in, which ADKAR element is the likeliest block? What would you check first?

Week 5 **Framework**

Lewin, K. (1947). Frontiers in group dynamics. *Human Relations*, 1(1), 5 to 41. Kotter, J. P. (1996). *Leading Change*. Harvard Business School Press.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Lewin's model treats change as three phases: unfreeze the current state, move to the new one, and refreeze so that the new way becomes stable. A pilot is a controlled unfreeze: it loosens existing habits in a small, protected setting where learning is cheap. Kotter's eight steps describe the leadership work of large scale change. Steps 3 to 5 are central to rolling out HR technology: develop a vision and strategy, communicate it widely and repeatedly, and empower people to act by removing obstacles. Kotter sees these steps as needing speed once urgency (Step 1) and a guiding coalition (Step 2) are in place.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Lewin: unfreeze, change, refreeze; a pilot unfreezes safely.
- Refreezing is what turns a successful pilot into normal practice.
- Kotter Steps 3 to 5: vision, communication, empowerment by removing obstacles.
- The two models answer different questions: Lewin describes phases, Kotter prescribes leadership actions.

APPLY IT

If you recommend a pilot, state what it will unfreeze, how you will judge it, and what would trigger refreezing at scale.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Lewin's unfreeze is not the same as Kotter's urgency step, although both prepare people for change.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Which Kotter step does a frontline champion network serve? Which obstacle does it remove?

Week 5 **Framework**

Rogers, E. M. (2003). *Diffusion of Innovations* (5th ed.). Free Press.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Everett Rogers explains how innovations spread through a social system over time. Adopters fall into categories: innovators, early adopters, early majority, late majority and laggards. Early adopters are especially important because they are respected opinion leaders whom others watch. Five attributes of an innovation affect how fast it spreads: relative advantage, compatibility with existing values and practice, complexity, trialability and observability. Diffusion works through networks: people adopt when trusted peers show that the innovation works.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Adopter categories from innovators to laggards.
- Early adopters are opinion leaders; recruit them as champions.
- Five attributes speed or slow spread, including trialability and observability.
- Spread runs through social networks, not only official channels.

APPLY IT

A Rogers move recruits respected peers at each site to model use. It works where the barrier is social, not where the barrier is a missing device.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Do not confuse Everett M. Rogers with David L. Rogers, author of *The Digital Transformation Playbook* (Unit-1 Core), who writes about business strategy.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Which of Rogers' five attributes does a free trial week change? Which does a public leaderboard change?

Week 5 | Framework

Nudge and gamification in workplace technology.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Nudges (reminders, defaults, simple prompts) and gamification (points, badges, leaderboards) can raise activity quickly. Their limitation is well documented: extrinsic rewards create activity without necessarily creating capability or lasting commitment, and activity can fall when rewards stop. They also risk embarrassing people who struggle, for example on a public leaderboard. Used well, they reinforce behavior that people are already able and willing to perform.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Nudges and rewards change activity faster than they change capability.
- Activity can collapse when the reward is removed.
- Public rankings can shame those facing Access or Skills barriers.
- Best used as Reinforcement after Ability is in place.

APPLY IT

A rise in logins after a points scheme is not evidence of adoption. Compare logins with completed self-service transactions and adoption stage.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Gamification is not diffusion. Rogers spreads use through trusted people; gamification rewards individual activity.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- What evidence would show that a gamified campaign built capability rather than clicks?

Week 6 Core

Venkatesh, V., Morris, M. G., Davis, G. B., & Davis, F. D. (2003). User acceptance of information technology: Toward a unified view. *MIS Quarterly*, 27(3), 425 to 478.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Venkatesh and colleagues compared eight earlier models of technology acceptance and combined them into the Unified Theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology (UTAUT). Four factors explain intention and use: performance expectancy (the belief that the system helps me do my job), effort expectancy (how easy it is), social influence (whether important others think I should use it) and facilitating conditions (whether the infrastructure and support exist). The effects are moderated by gender, age, experience and whether use is voluntary. Facilitating conditions act directly on use, not only through intention.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Four determinants: performance expectancy, effort expectancy, social influence, facilitating conditions.
- Moderators: gender, age, experience and voluntariness of use.
- Social influence matters more when use is mandatory.
- Facilitating conditions shape actual use directly, which links UTAUT to device and connectivity access.

APPLY IT

Facilitating conditions connect UTAUT to the Access layer of digital inclusion. Read usage by device and connectivity before you blame motivation.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Which UTAUT factor would a peer champion program act on? Which one would a device subsidy act on?

Week 6 Core

Manuti, A., & de Palma, P. D. (2018). Chapters 4 and 5.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

The Week 6 chapters move from argument to evidence. They examine social collaboration platforms as tools for HR, and present the PPP3.0 case study of how an organization developed digital HRM practices. The authors argue that collaboration and communication tools succeed when HR frames them within the organization's culture and its people strategy. Where tools are introduced as standalone technical projects, adoption is shallow and the employment relationship can suffer.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Social collaboration platforms change how HR communicates and how employees connect.
- The PPP3.0 case shows digital HRM practice being built, not bought.
- Standalone technical rollouts tend to produce shallow adoption.

APPLY IT

Test any rollout plan: does it change only the tool, or also the practice and the culture around it?

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Pick one HR technology rollout. What part of HR practice, not technology, would have to change for it to succeed?

Matching the fix to the stuck point

If the barrier is…	The framework that fits	A fix that matches
No suitable device or connection	Digital inclusion: Access	Device access, shared kiosks, feature phone channels
Cannot use the system in real conditions	ADKAR: Ability	Coached practice on the job, simplified flows
Does not see why to change	ADKAR: Awareness or Desire	Evidence, manager messages, peer stories
Nobody nearby uses it	Rogers diffusion	Respected local champions
Untested at scale	Lewin: controlled unfreeze	A bounded pilot with clear success criteria
Early use fading	ADKAR: Reinforcement; nudges	Recognition, defaults, follow up

Key terms

Electronic HRM	The use of web and mobile technology to deliver HR practices and policies.
Facilitating conditions	In UTAUT, the infrastructure and support that make use possible.
Guiding coalition	Kotter's Step 2: a group with enough power and credibility to lead change.
Purpose limitation	Using personal data only for the purpose stated when it was collected.
System of Record	The single authoritative source of employee data.
Voluntariness	Whether system use is optional; it changes the weight of social influence.

References

Bondarouk, T., Parry, E., & Furtmueller, E. (2017). Electronic HRM: Four decades of research on adoption and consequences. *The International Journal of Human Resource Management*, 28(1), 98 to 131.

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The three layer architecture is the course's own framing and is not credited to Kavanagh. Lewin, Kotter, Rogers and Cavoukian are named in the round briefs; their original works are listed so you can trace each idea to its source.